

Working-session *synthesis*

Meeting #5 · June 24, 2026 — from plan to action.

Meeting #5 · Wednesday June 24, 2026 Present: Mario Ramos (Chairperson), Pedro Rosa (Facilitator), Munchie, Elliott, and committee members present. **Format:** Recorded working session at the gym. This session was a structured walk-through of the live working plan — each initiative and work stream taken in turn, with open decisions resolved or parked. Intended to be fed back into the canon knowledge repo.

TL;DR

This was an execution session, not a deliberation one. The committee walked the full working document top to bottom and turned most of its open items into owned next steps. The **fourth initiative — the Washington send-off — was formally confirmed**, bringing the active set to four (college visit, Washington send-off, summer retreat, ballgame), and its spend mechanism got locked: scholars build an **Amazon wish list against a per-scholar cap (~\$300)**, the committee orders it through a clean entity account, and the receipt is the record. The **college visit got a date target (July 6–7, the week after the holiday)** and a registration path. The **two-fund banking model was named — General Mission Fund and Discretionary Fund —** and a real blocker surfaced: **Chase won't run Zelle against the .community domain, so a .com is needed**. Infrastructure went one step further into practice (Workspace login + a receipt-capture habit), the consent form picked up four committee contacts, the signature-on-behalf-of-the-LLC protocol was reinforced, and the branding/outreach work stream (two-scale logo, cards, Instagram, donation site with recurring giving) was scoped for right after the first outing. Roughly **\$1,500 is already in hand** for the college trip; the only initiative likely to carry real dollars is the retreat, which is what the year's fundraising goal will be pegged to.

1. Four initiatives, now formally active

The session opened by confirming that the **Washington send-off** — surfaced last week — is now formally counted among the active initiatives. That brings the working set to **four**:

1. **College visit** (Illinois State University)
2. **Washington send-off** (a selective university summer program two scholars were accepted into)
3. **Summer retreat** (lead location: Beacon River Lodge; canoeing as a possible add-on)
4. **Ballgame** (a group outing — the lightest-weight of the four)

Each got its own pass below. The rest of the document — banking, infrastructure, forms, legal, branding — was walked as supporting work streams.

2. Washington send-off — controlled-spend mechanism locked

Two scholars were accepted into a selective university summer program and **depart July 26**. The program runs roughly a week, houses them in dorms, and provides transportation and meals — so the committee's job is narrow: **outfit them appropriately**. The program's own attire guidance was reviewed: **business-professional worn twice** (suit or sports jacket in a dark color, dress shirt, tie, dress shoes), **business-casual Monday–Thursday for lectures** (collared/polo shirts, slacks or khakis — *no jeans*; comfortable/athletic shoes acceptable), and casual after-hours, which the scholars already own.

The mechanism (decided): each scholar builds an **Amazon wish list, listed in order of importance**, and sends it to the committee. The committee orders against a **per-scholar spending cap (~\$300)** through a clean entity Amazon account and pays with the business card, so the **invoice itself is the record**. The cap lets scholars do their own comparison shopping and make their own choices within the budget; anything beyond the cap is on the family. Practical guidance to relay: two dress shirts, one or two pairs of slacks, a jacket or two that can be mixed and matched, ties, and clean shoes will go a long way — and Pedro can contribute ties from his own closet.

Timing matters. Scholars should be **ordering by next week** so there's a 3–4 week cushion before departure to exchange anything that doesn't fit. A soft order deadline of early next week was floated.

One open mechanism question got resolved on the spot: rather than routing wish lists through Mario's personal Amazon, the plan is to **stand up a new, clean Amazon account under the entity email** (mario.ramos@lafamilia.community) with the business card attached. Scholars send their lists to that account; purchases stay cleanly separated from anyone's personal history. (*Pedro to confirm the exact account-setup path.*)

3. College visit — date target and registration path

Date target: July 6 or 7 (Monday/Tuesday of the first full week of July, deliberately after the July 4 holiday so everyone's home). Backup is the following week (~July 13–14).

Cohort: three scholars are confirmed and warm to it, with a possible fourth pending outreach (he wasn't present and the committee doesn't yet have his contact info). A handful of others are in the maybe column depending on basketball schedules, plus one or two slightly older young men from the gym who could round out an even number. Counting two to three committee members riding along, the group lands around **six to eight** — which would split cleanly across two vehicles if needed.

Registration path (decided): Illinois State offers two routes — a free standard visit where each student is registered individually, or a **small-group visit at \$12/person** that includes a dedicated tour guide, the group kept together in its own space, an all-you-can-eat buffet, and possibly group t-shirts. The committee is leaning toward the **group visit** — the modest cost is worth the cohesion and it's simple to set up now that everyone's intake info will be on file.

Dependencies: lock the date once scholars confirm, then register. The **intake form and the trip-specific guardian consent need to be completed first** (see §5). Funds are not a constraint here —

roughly **\$1,500 is already in hand** for the college trip, with some expected to be left over.

4. Summer retreat — feeler call before committing

The retreat (lead location **Beacon River Lodge**) is on an intentional **slow roll**, targeted for **early August**. The only outstanding pieces are **dates and budget**.

Next step (Mario): call the lodge to put out a feeler — group availability in early August, how much lead time/notice they need, and deposit terms (one comparable place wanted half the cost two weeks out; a small deposit, ~\$250, may hold dates). A backup location (Kickapoo) is in reserve. A **canoeing day (4–6 hours)** may be folded in, and its cost rolled into the same budget number.

This is the **one initiative likely to carry real dollars** (potentially a few thousand), which is why it anchors the year's fundraising goal (see §10).

5. Ballgame — low-cost group outing

Deliberately the lightest initiative. **500-level tickets run roughly \$13–20**, so it's something to **pencil in whenever a gap opens** between the other events. Mario will reach out to a ticketing contact to ask about **group or organization rates** before locking anything. A couple of the newer young men from the gym may be invited to this one.

6. Banking — the .com blocker and the two-fund model

The blocker: Chase **will not run Zelle against the .community domain — it requires a .com**. So the first action out of this meeting is to **secure a .com and integrate it with the existing .community setup** so everything stays in one place. (*Pedro to handle; "Bob" assisting on the integration.*) The Chase account itself is already open, and the domain and email are already reserved.

The two-fund model (named and decided):

- **General Mission Fund** — the primary fund. This is where donor contributions land and where the mission and its initiatives are funded from, including ordinary operating costs (application fees, gas, and the like). This is the fund donors are told about.
- **Discretionary Fund** — a committee fund for legitimate costs *above and beyond what a typical donor would expect to cover* — e.g., the marginal difference when a committee member needs their own room rather than bunking, or a meal upgrade while traveling on the initiative's behalf. Only the **difference above the base cost** is drawn here; the base cost always comes from the General Mission Fund. This fund is **not advertised** — it's disclosed only to specific donors who understand how initiatives like this run and choose to support it directly. Recurring or informed donors can elect which fund to support.

The committee spent real time on naming (working through "operating," "stewardship," "mission," "counselor support," and others) and **landed on General Mission Fund + Discretionary Fund** —

"mission" reads warm and descriptive; "discretionary" is literal about what the fund is for, and anyone who'd ask "what does that mean?" is simply pointed to the General Mission Fund instead.

Next step (Mario): once the .com is in place, talk to Chase about (a) standing up the two accounts and (b) whether the separation can live inside a single account. Mario will push to keep it to one account if there's a clean way; absent anything better, the default is **two separate accounts** — roughly \$15/mo each (~\$180/yr), paid out of the Discretionary Fund. An initial discretionary seed of around **\$1,000** is expected to carry things for a while.

7. Infrastructure — from stood-up to in-use

The domain and email are reserved and Google Workspace is up. The focus now is **getting Mario actually using it from his phone**:

- **Confirm login** to the business email and **Google Drive** (Pedro to walk him through it live).
 - **Receipt-capture habit**: photograph every receipt (gas, purchases) so they're always in Google Photos; batch-download and upload them into a Drive archive when convenient. Longer term, move to **QuickBooks** or similar. The near-term priority is simply *capture* — don't lose the paper.
 - **Mobile-first is the explicit operating principle**. Almost everything the committee does happens on phones; desktop is reserved for the occasional task that benefits from a bigger screen (e.g., the Amazon ordering). Everything built should work mobile-first and still hold up on desktop.
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8. Forms & intake — consent form picks up four contacts

Paper forms remain the approach for this round; online forms are a future goal. Two forms are in play: the **intake / personal-info sheet** and the **trip-specific guardian consent**.

- The physical intake sheet got damaged — **Munchie to reprint** (he has all four).
- **Consent form update (Pedro, today)**: add **four committee-member contact entries** so a parent can always reach more than one of the adults; guardians need only fill out what's relevant. Write the trip details in as "**July 6 or 7 (TBD)**" so parents can review ahead of the locked date.
- **Tomorrow (committee)**: hand scholars both forms — complete the intake on-site at the park, and send the consent home for parents to review, with the note that final date/details follow once locked.

Background checks remain **deferred to next year**, consistent with prior sessions.

9. Legal & signature posture — reinforced

- **Signature protocol:** whenever Mario signs anything on the group's behalf (booking rooms, reserving the lodge, etc.), he signs his own name **and adds "on behalf of La Familia Community Scholarship LLC."** That makes the LLC the signing party and protects him personally. This was reinforced as standard, expected practice — vendors often prefer signing with an entity. The same applies to endorsing any checks or money orders received: sign as the entity.
 - **Gift posture reaffirmed.** Contributions this year are **gifts** — the initiative is not yet a nonprofit, so they are **not tax-deductible**. For family-and-friends gifts the committee can stay light. But any donor **outside the inner circle**, and **especially any gift above ~\$5,000**, should sign the **gift acknowledgment** — the existing canonical form — to keep things clean. Big or out-of-state gifts can be handled by DocuSign (~\$3) or a photographed/PDF'd sign-and-return. Once online payments are live, acknowledgment becomes a **required checkbox** in the donation flow.
 - **Zelle memo convention (Munchie's call):** ask senders to write "gift" in the Zelle message field. The recipient can see the memo in history, so it's a clean, low-effort record. Adopt as a near-term reminder.
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10. Branding & outreach — scoped for after the first outing

This work stream is sequenced to follow the first real outing, so there's content to show.

- **Logo:** a couple of scholar concepts are in hand — an "LF + basketball" mark and a "circle of family/people holding hands with LF in the center." The committee liked the idea of **blending them** (a basketball whose outline is the joined hands). Key requirement: **two scales** of the mark — a detailed large version and a simplified small version that survives shrinking to a business card or jersey (Google's full wordmark vs. the single "G" is the model). Smallest might be just "LF + basketball." **Next step:** scholars send their concepts; manage expectations that they may be tweaked for fidelity at small sizes.
 - **Cards & merch:** once the logo is set, produce business cards (with a **QR code** to the donation site and/or Instagram), plus t-shirts, jerseys, and caps. Munchie has a printing/apparel contact.
 - **Instagram:** stand up a page for **real-time documentation** so donors can see the work happening (trip photos and video). Set it up **after the first outing**, with a shared login so multiple committee members can post. Munchie to look into the mechanics.
 - **Donation site:** Pedro can build an online donation/payment page once the bank accounts exist. **Merchant fee ~3–4%** — decide whether the donor covers it (likely an opt-in "cover the fee" checkbox) or the org absorbs it.
 - **Recurring giving:** when the site opens up, offer a **recurring option (e.g., \$20/month)** alongside one-time gifts — easier to commit to, predictable, and something the committee can plan against. Donors can change or cancel anytime.
 - **Fundraising goal:** decide whether to set a year target. The plan is to **peg it to the retreat cost** (the one initiative with real dollars), folding in the canoeing day. Mario gets that number from his lodge call, then the committee sets the target.
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Action items

Pedro (Facilitator)

- Secure a **.com domain** and integrate it with **.community** so Chase Zelle works.
- **Update the consent form** today: four committee contacts + "July 6/7 (TBD)" trip details; share with the committee.
- **Walk Mario through** his business-email and Google Drive login (live, on his phone).
- Confirm the path to **stand up a clean entity Amazon account** (mario.ramos@lafamilia.community, business card attached) for the Washington send-off orders.
- Once accounts exist, **build the online donation page** and research recurring-payment + merchant-fee handling.

Mario (Chairperson)

- **Resend / collect the Washington attire list**; tomorrow, tell the two scholars to build Amazon wish lists (in priority order) against a **~\$300 cap**, ordering by next week.
- **Call Beacon River Lodge** for an early-August availability/deposit feeler; get a rough retreat budget number.
- **Call the ticketing contact** about group/organization ballgame rates.
- After the **.com** lands, **talk to Chase** about the two accounts (General Mission + Discretionary) and whether one account can hold the separation.
- Begin the **receipt-photo habit** for all initiative spending.
- Apply the **"on behalf of the LLC"** signature on anything signed for the group.

Munchie

- **Reprint the intake form** (and bring copies for tomorrow).
- **Look into the Instagram** setup (shared login) ahead of the first outing.
- Line up the **printing/apparel contact** for cards and merch once the logo is set.

Committee (tomorrow at the park)

- Hand scholars the **intake (complete on-site)** and the **consent (take home to parents)**.
- Confirm **July 6 vs. 7** with the scholars so the college-visit date can lock.
- Relay the **Washington wish-list + cap** instructions to the two send-off scholars.

Open decisions (status)

#	Item	Status
1	Washington send-off spend mechanism	Resolved — Amazon wish list → entity account → invoice as record; ~\$300 cap
2	College-visit consent details	Pending — write-in updated; finalizes when the date locks

#	Item	Status
3	Gift-form / Zelle destination	Resolved (interim) — "gift" in the Zelle memo; revisit once the business email is attached
4	Fundraising goal for the year	Pending — peg to the retreat (and canoeing) cost after Mario's lodge call
5	Retreat dates / budget / backup	Pending — Mario's feeler call; Kickapoo as backup
6	Second bank account vs. single-account separation	Pending — gated on the .com, then the Chase conversation
7	Background checks	Parked — Year 2 / backlog
8	Scholarship-application window	Folded in — covered by the intake forms already in progress; treated as non-distinct

Four initiatives live. The mechanism is set, the dates are nearly locked, and the next step is simply getting the young men outfitted and on the road.